



WHEN EARLY PIONEERS BEGAN RAISING HORSES in the Oregon desert, a number of spirited creatures regularly broke through their restrictive fencing and headed for the open range. Also, when times were so hard that desperate ranchers could not afford to buy feed, they would release their prize stock to fend for themselves rather than allow them to starve. For decades, the wild herds doubled in size every few years, and thousands were captured by opportunists and sold off for slaughter. Finally, in 1971, Oregon's legislature passed the Wild Free-Roaming Horses and Burros Act, which assigned responsibility for their care to the state Bureau of Land Management. Today, the BLM manages the rangeland so it is able to support the herds, and makes sure that sick and injured animals are cared for. Every year, they also gather in hundreds of healthy horses and burros (donkeys) and find permanent homes for them under the hugely successful "Adopt-a-Horse" program.

